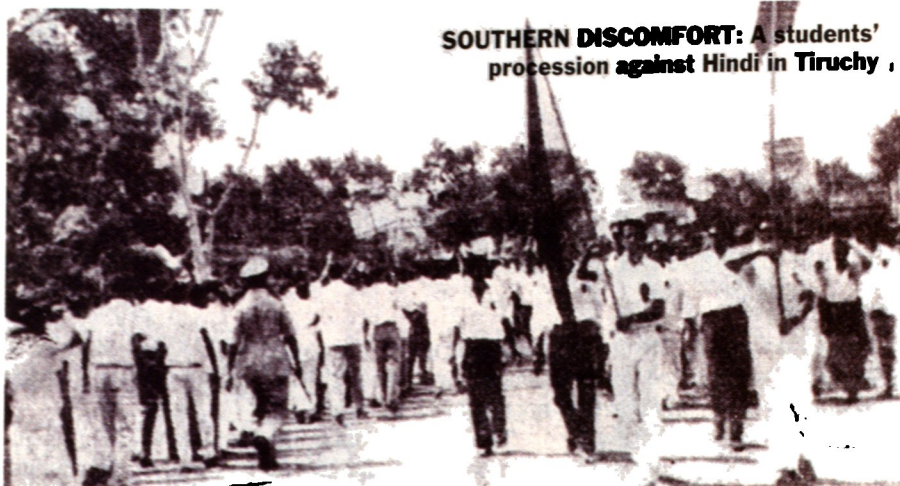


## ANTI-HINDI AGITATION



**SOUTHERN DISCOMFORT:** A students' procession against Hindi in Tiruchy

C.N. ANNADURAI, Tamil Nadu CM, 1963

**"It is the duty of the Tamil people to wage war on those who impose Hindi."**

less debates, and consequent confusion, in defining Hindi and Hindustani and its relationship with Urdu and north Indian Muslims. Linguistic reorganisation of provincial Congress committees was then little more than pragmatic acceptance of ground reality.

The most acrimonious debates in the Constituent Assembly were, interestingly, not on a common civil code but on the question of official language of the Indian Union. The arguments demonstrate that both sides viewed language as underpinning national unity—if the Hindi zealots saw it as a unifying force, its opponents saw its imposition on the south as the cause of discord. In the event, the story, most certainly apocryphal, of Hindi nudging its nose at the finishing line by the casting vote of the chairman, did little to legitimise its new constitutional status. The 15-year deadline for English to be an associate official language only postponed the day of reckoning.

**T**he force of sentiment against Hindi could not have been lost on the members of the Constituent Assembly. For barely a decade earlier the Congress government in Madras Presidency had faced a most popular (which included Muslims as well) agitation against the teaching of Hindi compulsorily in schools. The Congress's use of the same brutal colonial methods they had earlier condemned, added to the force of the movement. The anti-Hindi agitation of 1937-39 made a Periyar (the venerated one) of E. V. Ramasamy. The years leading up to January 26, 1965, when Hindi would become the sole official language, were marked by continued arguments and debates. DMK was to spearhead the decisive anti-Hindi agitation of the 1960s. New converts were won—P. Subbarayan, who had at best

been evasive in the Constituent Assembly, Suniti Kumar Chatterji and the sagely C. Rajagopalachari who had faced the brunt of the 1937-39 anti-Hindi agitation, which gave legitimacy to the movement.

Paradoxically, nobody strengthened the case against Hindi more than the Hindi fanatics themselves. Countering that Hindi was the language of the majority, former chief minister C.N. Annadurai brilliantly quipped that, in that case, the common crow and not the peacock would have to be India's national bird. Jawaharlal Nehru's legally-not-binding assurance that English would remain as long as the south wanted it to did little to solve the problem. Every successive move by the state to solve the problem—for instance, the Official Language Act, 1963—were seen as pandering to Hindi demands.

With DMK declaring January 26, 1965, as a day of mourning, the stage was set for unprecedented turmoil in independent India. A moderate Rajagopalachari suggested Part XVII of the Constitution containing the section on the official language of the Union, "be heaved and thrown into the Arabian Sea", while DMK announced its burning. Thousands were arrested and top DMK leaders incarcerated, lending them an aura which was converted into electoral power in a few years. DMK, however, was not a lone regional swallow in the Indian unionist summer. The Congress fell in over half a dozen states signalling the rise of regional political parties which since 1989 have decided the fate of India's political present and future. They also remain the bulwark against the Hindu homogeneity that BJP is trying to forge. The language question is far from settled. But perhaps what politics could not solve, globalisation and technology have mitigated to an extent.

**1965**

January 26 was declared a day of mourning in the south by an anti-Hindi DMK

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